

Autonomy Of Local Assembly

doc-autonomy-of-local-assembly

Ecclesiology · Nature of the Church · doctrine · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

score 0.725
confidence medium

Statement under examination

Each local assembly is autonomous under Christ's headship, governed by its own elders, not subordinate to a denominational hierarchy or external bishop.

In plain language

The Greek behind these passages gives a clear, consistent picture for one half of the question. In Acts 14:23 Paul and Barnabas appoint elders church by church, and in Titus 1:5 Titus appoints elders city by city. The same small word *kata* distributes a group of elders, never a single ruler, across each town. In Acts 20 the very men called elders in verse 17 are called overseers in verse 28, so elder and overseer are two names for one office, and they shepherd the flock of God in their own city. First Peter 5 agrees: the writer calls himself a fellow elder, not a bishop above the elders, the elders shepherd the flock that is among them, they must not lord it over the people, and Christ alone is named the Chief Shepherd over them all. That much the words support strongly. What the words cannot prove is the second half, that no wider authority exists. The same verb that tells Titus to appoint local elders, *diatasso*, is the verb Paul uses when he says he gives the same order in all the churches in First Corinthians 7:17, and again for the offering across many churches. In Acts 16:4 decrees decided by the apostles and elders at Jerusalem are carried to the local churches, city by city, to keep. The word church itself names both a single local assembly, like the church of Ephesus or each of the seven churches in Revelation, and one larger church that Christ builds. Because the same authority words and the same word church reach both the local and the wider level, the text settles who governs a congregation locally but does not rank a fully independent model against a connected one. For that reason this proposition is best recorded as genuinely contested, well grounded in its positive half, unsettled in its negative half.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0750	ἀρχιποίμην	archipoimēn	chief shepherd	1
G1299	διατάσσω	diatassō	to direct	16
G1378	δόγμα	dogma	decree	5
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklēsia	assembly	114
G1985	ἐπίσκοπος	episkopos	overseer	5
G2525	καθίστημι	kathistēmi	to appoint/conduct	21
G2596	κατά	kata	according to	477
G2634	κατακυριεύω	katakyrieuō	to master	4
G2819	κλήρος	klēros	lot	
G2919	κρίνω	krinō	to judge	

G4165	ποιμαίνω	poimainō	to shepherd	11
G4168	ποίμνιον	poimnion	flock	5
G4172	πόλις	polis	city	
G4245	πρεσβύτερος	presbyteros	elder	66
G4850	συμπρεσβύτερος	sympresbyteros	fellow elder	1
G5500	χειροτονέω	cheirotoneō	to appoint	2

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

Direct queries confirm the positive half of the proposition with grammatical precision. Each local body receives its own plurality of elders, distributively (Acts 14:23 χειροτονήσαντες πρεσβυτέρους G4245 plural with κατ' ἐκκλησίαν, Titus 1:5 πρεσβυτέρους κατὰ πόλιν), and the same plural cohort named πρεσβυτέρους in Acts 20:17 is renamed ἐπισκόπους G1985 in Acts 20:28, so elder and overseer are one office over one local flock, with Christ alone as ἀρχιποίμην G0750 (hapax, 1 Pet 5:4). What the lexicon does not establish is the negative claim of non-subordination. The very verb of Titus 1:5's local directive, διατάσσω G1299, is the verb Paul applies to all the churches at once in 1 Cor 7:17 (ἐν ταῖς ἐκκλησίαις πάσαις διατάσσομαι) and 1 Cor 16:1, and at Acts 16:4 binding decrees (δόγματα G1378, κεκριμένα G2919) from the Jerusalem assembly are delivered to the local churches κατὰ τὰς πόλεις to keep. Because ἐκκλησία G1577 itself denotes both the single local assembly and the one supra-local church, and the same authority vocabulary reaches both levels, the polity scope is materially contested and the verdict is recorded as disputed.

Scripture

Acts.14.23 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G5500 χειροτονέω, G4245 πρεσβύτερος, G2596 κατὰ, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Force. Queried morphology reads χειροτονήσαντες (G5500, aorist active participle) πρεσβυτέρους (G4245, accusative plural) κατ' ἐκκλησίαν (G2596 preposition, distributive in every church). The preposition κατὰ here is distributive, placing a plurality of elders in each individual congregation. The grammar secures local elder governance but is silent about any higher coordinating structure either way. χειροτονέω is rare: only one other genuine occurrence (2 Cor 8:19), where a man is chosen by the churches plural for the collection, so the appointment verb itself appears in a trans-local coordination setting too.

Titus.1.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2525 καθίστημι, G4245 πρεσβύτερος, G2596 κατὰ, G1299 διατάσσω, G4172 πόλις

Force. Titus is to καταστήσης (G2525, appoint) πρεσβυτέρους κατὰ πόλιν (G2596 plus G4172, city by city), the same distributive κατὰ as Acts 14:23, grounding a local plurality per town. Decisively, the verse states the appointment proceeds because Paul διεταξάμην (G1299, first person singular, I directed). The identical verb G1299 reappears in 1 Cor 7:17 directed at all the churches, so the very word that authorizes local elders is also the word for trans-local apostolic ordering. This is why the verse simultaneously supports local elders and complicates a strict no-external-authority reading.

Acts.20.17 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4245 πρεσβύτερος, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Force. Paul summons the πρεσβυτέρους (G4245, accusative plural) of τῆς ἐκκλησίας (G1577, genitive singular) of one city, Ephesus. The plural elders are the standing leadership of a single local congregation, and that single local assembly is the addressed unit.

Acts.20.28 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1985 ἐπίσκοπος, G4165 ποιμαίνω, G4168 ποίμνιον, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Force. The same men called πρεσβυτέρους in verse 17 are here named ἐπισκόπους (G1985, accusative plural), set in office by the Holy Spirit, charged to ποιμαίνειν (G4165) τὴν ἐκκλησίαν τοῦ θεοῦ over the ποιμνίῳ (G4168). Elder and overseer are grammatically one office, the same plural cohort under two titles, over one local flock. No higher human officer is named as the source of their charge; the Spirit and the God who purchased the church are. ἐπίσκοπος also appears as a plural in one city at Phil 1:1, reinforcing local plurality.

1Pet.5.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4850 συμπρεσβύτερος, G4245 πρεσβύτερος

Force. Peter addresses elders as a συμπρεσβύτερος (G4850, a hapax, fellow elder), not as a ruling bishop above them. The compound levels the writer with the local elders rather than placing him over a graded hierarchy of them, which weighs against a single external bishop ruling congregations from above.

1Pet.5.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4165 ποιμαίνω, G4168 ποίμνιον, G1985 ἐπίσκοπος

Force. Elders are told ποιμάνετε (G4165) τὸ ἐν ὑμῖν ποίμνιον (G4168, the flock that is among you), ἐπισκοποῦντες (cognate of G1985, exercising oversight). The phrase that is among you locates the flock as their own immediate congregation, and the oversight verb again coincides with the elder noun in one office.

1Pet.5.3 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2634 κατακυριεύω, G2819 κλήρος, G4168 ποίμνιον

Force. Elders are not to be κατακυριεύοντες τῶν κλήρων (G2634 plus G2819, lording it over those allotted) but τύποι, examples. κατακυριεύω is rare (G2634, four occurrences, twice of Gentile rulers in Mark 10:42 and Matt 20:25). The prohibition constrains the manner of governance but says nothing about its scope, so it neither establishes nor rules out trans-local structure.

1Pet.5.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0750 ἀρχιποίμην

Force. Christ is the ἀρχιποίμην (G0750, Chief Shepherd, a hapax confirmed by direct query as occurring only here) before whom the under-shepherd elders give account. The single supreme head over all elders grounds the Christ headship clause of the proposition but is silent on whether intermediate human structures exist beneath that headship.

Acts.16.4 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1378 δόγμα, G2919 κρίνω, G4172 πόλις

Force. Queried morphology reads τὰ δόγματα (G1378, accusative plural neuter, the decrees) τὰ κεκριμένα (G2919, perfect passive participle, having been decided) ὑπὸ τῶν ἀποστόλων καὶ πρεσβυτέρων, which they παρεδίδοσαν (delivered) to the local assemblies φυλάσσειν (to keep) κατὰ τὰς πόλεις (G4172, throughout the cities). A decision made by the Jerusalem assembly is binding and is distributed to the local churches city by city. This is trans-local authority reaching into local congregations and is the central datum complicating strict autonomy.

1Cor.7.17 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1299 διατάσσω, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Force. The verse closes ἐν ταῖς ἐκκλησίαις πάσαις διατάσσομαι (G1299, present middle indicative first person, thus in all the churches I prescribe), with ἐκκλησίαις (G1577, dative plural). The identical authority verb that installs local elders in Titus 1:5 is here exercised over all churches simultaneously. The same word spanning both levels is precisely why the vocabulary cannot rank a fully autonomous polity against a connectional one.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Acts.20.28	1Pet.5.2	openbible	37
1Pet.5.3	Ezek.34.4	openbible	11
Acts.14.23	Titus.1.5	openbible	10
Acts.20.28	Ps.74.2	openbible	8
Acts.20.28	Acts.20.29	openbible	7
1Pet.5.1	1Pet.5.4	openbible	5
Acts.16.4	Acts.15.28	openbible	5

Complicating texts

Acts.16.4 · addressed

Direct query confirms τὰ δόγματα G1378 τὰ κεκριμένα G2919 by the apostles and elders were delivered to the local assemblies κατὰ τὰς πόλεις to keep. This is a verified trans-local act of binding authority distributed to local congregations, cutting against strict congregational independence. It does not establish a permanent denominational hierarchy, but it does show authority flowing beyond a single local elder body, which is the principal reason the autonomy claim is recorded as disputed rather than affirmed.

Acts.15.22 · addressed

Query confirms ἔδοξεν G1380 τοῖς ἀποστόλοις καὶ τοῖς πρεσβυτέροις σὺν ὅλῃ τῇ ἐκκλησίᾳ (G1577, dative singular, the whole church) at Jerusalem, with the burden language βάρος G0922 in v. 28. A conciliar body deliberates and decides for assemblies beyond itself. The text shows trans-local conciliar authority without setting up a standing hierarchy, so it qualifies the no-external-authority half of the stem.

1Cor.7.17 · addressed

The verb διατάσσω G1299 that installs local elders in Titus 1:5 is here exercised over all the churches at once (ἐν ταῖς ἐκκλησίαις πάσαις). 1 Cor 16:1 uses the same verb for the collection across the churches of Galatia. The single vocabulary covering both local and trans-local ordering means the words themselves do not delimit the scope of legitimate authority, so the negative clause of the proposition is lexically underdetermined.

Acts.9.31 · unaddressed

Query shows ἐκκλησία G1577 here is N-NSF, nominative singular, in NA28, SBL, WH, and Tregelles (the church throughout all Judea and Galilee and Samaria), while TR and Byzantine read the plural ἐκκλησίαι. This bears on whether the canon speaks of one supra-local church spanning regions, but the textual split is itself unresolved at the lexical level and the polity-scope verdict does not turn on it, so it is left open rather than adjudicated here.

Concordance traversed

G1577, G4245, G1985, G4165, G4168, G5500, G2525, G0750, G4850, G2596, G1299, G1378, G2919, G2634, G2819

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

Acts.20.28-theou-kyriou at Acts.20.28: impact none. The θεοῦ versus κυρίου variant (church of God versus church of the Lord) affects Christology and the purchase clause but does not bear on the polity question of local elder governance, so the polity verdict is variant robust.

Acts.9.31-ekklesia-number at Acts.9.31: impact minor. Critical text reads ἐκκλησία singular (N-NSF in NA28, SBL, WH, Treg), TR and Byzantine read plural ἐκκλησίαι. This nudges the universal church reading but does not settle the autonomy scope, so impact on this verdict is minor, not material.

Neither anchor variant falls in the 3 John ECM window, so no CBGM data was examined; this NT material is ecm-shadow. The bundle reported not_in_ecm_scope true with zero variant units, but direct query surfaced the two textual points above, neither of which overturns the polity reading.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. congregationalism, presbyterianism, episcopalianism

analogia scripturae invoked

congregationalism: affirms · Reads the distributive κατ' ἐκκλησίαν and κατὰ πόλιν, the elder equals overseer identity confirmed across Acts 20:17 and 28, the fellow elder self description of 1 Pet 5:1, and Christ as the sole ἀρχιποίμην, as establishing a self governing local assembly under Christ with no permanent human officer above the local eldership in the text. Treats the Jerusalem decree and apostolic directives as a temporary apostolic foundation, not a standing supra-local court.

presbyterianism: disputed · Accepts the local plurality of elders and the elder overseer identity, but reads Acts 15 to 16 (the binding δόγματα delivered to the churches), the trans-local directive verb διατάσσω in 1 Cor 7:17, and the coordinated collection across churches in 1 Cor 16 and 2 Cor 8, as warranting an ongoing connectional authority of assembled elders, so the no hierarchy clause is not lexically secured.

episcopalianism: false · Points to Titus appointing elders κατὰ πόλιν under Paul's personal διατάξαι, and to a single delegate installing and ordering elders across multiple congregations, reading the same data as a regional or monarchical oversight pattern in which a single overseer ranks above local elderships, which it takes to contradict strict local autonomy.

The positive elements (local plurality of elders, elder equals overseer, Christ as sole Chief Shepherd) are lexically secure across all three lenses and are not in dispute. The division is over the negative clause of non-subordination, which the lexicon underdetermines because the same authority vocabulary, especially διατάσσω G1299 and the conciliar decree language of Acts 15 to 16, reaches both the local and the trans-local level. Hebrew background texts (Ezek 34, Isa 56) reinforce the shepherd flock relation through the cross references but do not settle polity scope.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine how the New Testament describes the governance of a local assembly, including who appoints and oversees its leaders, and what relationship, if any, the text shows between one assembly's leadership and any wider authority.

The stem is verdict preloaded in two ways. The word autonomous and the clause not subordinate to a denominational hierarchy or external bishop assert a contested negative conclusion before the evidence is weighed, and denominational hierarchy and external bishop are tradition specific targets that the first century vocabulary does not frame. The verdict was derived on the original stem; the neutral rephrasing isolates the lexical question (who appoints, who oversees, what wider relation) from the polity conclusion. Verdict unchanged from the prior file: still disputed, now grounded by direct queries that confirmed both the local elder pattern and the trans-local decree and directive pattern.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.14.23
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Titus.1.5

morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.20.28
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.16.4
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Cor.7.17
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.9.31
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0750
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1299
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Acts.20.28
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Acts.16.4

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

Flags

ecm-shadow · lexically-disputed · complicating-unresolved · cross-tradition-divergent